

Robot Runs Half-Marathon Faster Than Any Human -- and It's Just Getting Started

From: Physics World Mined: 2026-06-09 3 min read

Imagine a robot sprinting past you at a race and winning! That's what happened in Beijing last April. A **humanoid** robot ran a **half-marathon** (about 13 miles) in just 50 minutes and 26 seconds. That's almost seven minutes faster than the best human time, set by Kenya's Sabastian Sawe a week earlier. What's even wilder? The year before, the winning robot took 2 hours and 40 minutes. In one year, robots got more than twice as fast. How? Better hardware and smarter **AI**. New robot legs have powerful motors that act like super-strong muscles. They're also built to copy the way ostriches and emus run light and bouncy, wasting less energy. **Liquid cooling** stops them from overheating, just like sweat cools you down. But the real game-changer is **AI**. Robots are learning to see, understand words, and turn them into actions. It's called a Vision-Language-Action model, or **VLA**. Think of it like this: you see a ball, hear "kick it," and your brain tells your leg to swing. A **VLA** does the same for a robot. It can even figure out new tasks it wasn't directly taught. In China, robots are already being trained to do the trickiest **car-factory** jobs like plugging in wires and fitting seats. These jobs need careful fingers and quick thinking, which used to be too hard for machines. Now, with **AI**, robots might soon work beside humans, learning as they go. It's a little like a sci-fi movie coming true. But instead of being scared, scientists are excited. One day, robots might help in homes, hospitals, and places we can't even imagine yet. That **half-marathon** was just a warm-up lap.

Word Treasure

humanoid -- A robot that is shaped like a person, with a head, two arms, and two legs.

half-marathon -- A running race that is about 13 miles, or half the length of a full marathon.

AI -- Short for Artificial Intelligence -- a computer program that can learn and make decisions like a brain.

VLA -- A Vision-Language-Action model, which lets robots understand what they see, hear words, and turn them into movements.

liquid cooling -- A way to keep machines from overheating by moving cool liquid through them, like sweat cools a body.

car-factory -- A large building where cars are put together by machines and people.

Background you need

The race took place in Beijing, the capital city of China. A week earlier, Sabastian Sawe (a long-distance runner from Kenya) had set the human record for the same distance -- but the robot beat his time by almost seven minutes.

Humanoid robots are machines built to move and look like people. They compete in special races to test how fast and smart they have become.

Break it down

WHO: A humanoid robot and Kenyan runner Sabastian Sawe.

WHAT: The robot ran a half-marathon in 50:26, beating the human record by nearly seven minutes and improving hugely from the previous year.

WHERE: In Beijing, China.

WHY: New powerful legs, liquid cooling, and a VLA brain let the robot think, see, and run far better than before.

Why it matters

If robots can learn to run and think this quickly, they might soon become helpers in schools, hospitals, and even at your own home.

Test what you remember

1. Where did the robot run its half-marathon?

- ☐ (A) Beijing
- ☐ (B) Tokyo
- ☐ (C) New York
- ☐ (D) Nairobi

2. How fast did the robot finish the race?

- ☐ (A) 50 minutes and 26 seconds
- ☐ (B) 2 hours and 40 minutes
- ☐ (C) Exactly 60 minutes
- ☐ (D) 45 minutes

3. Who held the previous best human half-marathon time mentioned in the article?

- ☐ (A) Sebastian Sawe
- ☐ (B) Eliud Kipchoge
- ☐ (C) Usain Bolt
- ☐ (D) Michael Phelps

4. How much faster did the robot run compared to the winning robot the year before?

- ☐ (A) More than twice as fast
- ☐ (B) About the same speed
- ☐ (C) A little slower
- ☐ (D) Three times faster

5. Which animals' running style did the robot's legs copy?

- ☐ (A) Ostriches and emus
- ☐ (B) Cheetahs
- ☐ (C) Horses
- ☐ (D) Kangaroos

6. What does the acronym VLA stand for?

- ☐ (A) Vision-Language-Action
- ☐ (B) Very Large Animal
- ☐ (C) Virtual Learning Assistant
- ☐ (D) Voice-Language-Animation

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: A 3: A 4: A 5: A 6: A

Questions to think about

1. Scientists are excited: They believe robots getting faster and smarter means they will soon safely work beside people in factories, hospitals, and homes, making life easier.

2. Some people worry about the future: They fear that robots might take over people's jobs or become too independent and hard to control.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):